Q+A

Truly Classic

Padma Shri awardee **Shubha Mudgal**, one of the curators of the Serendipity Arts Festival 2025, on what she has planned for its music section

Q. As one of the curators of the music section for the Serendipity Arts Festival this year, can you tell us what visitors can expect?

There are three projects I am working on for SAF this year, all curated jointly with Dr Aneesh Pradhan. In the inaugural act, titled 'Clay Play', we bring together percussion instruments essentially made from clay. Our second project, 'Serendipity Soundscapes 2025', features groups that will present music from Gujarat and Bengal. Our third project is '1871 in 2025: The Parsi Gayan Uttejak Mandali'. Based entirely on Aneesh's research in the area of Hindustani music in colonial Bombay, this will be a reconstruction of the first jalsa or concert held by the mandali on April 28, 1871.

Q. How much have your roots in classical music helped you stay true to your craft, while exploring other genres such as pop music?

My training and abiding love for classical music are truly my anchor for all my musical experiments and collaborations. I draw on my training in Hindustani music to help me find an entry point into another system of music, and help me negotiate and learn from other forms and systems.

Q. As someone who has been singing professionally for more than four decades, what are some of the positive changes you have seen in the field of music in these past few years?

Change, of course, is inevitable. But what may be positive for me might be the opposite for another musician in another situation. The one welcome change for me has been the internet's ability to give listeners access to music from around the world.

Q. It has been many years since 'Ab Ke Sawan' and 'Ali More Angna', but people still remember them fondly. How do you look back on your journey with pop music?

Yes, it has been about a quarter of a century since I recorded both these tracks, and it is wonderful that these tracks still find listeners. I enjoyed my occasional interaction with popular music and continue to do so on the few occasions when I am invited to sing something that does not fall into the strictly classical category.

—with Deepali Dhingra



Photograph by DIVYA JAIN